India’s policy on nuclear weapons was also framed by the desire to be independent, to be unique and to ensure full strategic space. Nehru championed disarmament – conventional and nuclear – and yet understood the benefits of nuclear energy as well as the wherewithal for a future nuclear weapons programme. His successors Indira and Rajiv continued with his policies and in 1974 India conducted her first tests. Despite international pressure, India continued to build its nuclear weapons programme independently and was ready to test by the early 1990s. For India, nuclear weapons represented a combination of prestige, security and capability. For India, nuclear disarmament is the ideal but as long as other powers possess nukes, India must maintain a nuclear arsenal too. At the same time, there has always been the view that India would disarm as part of global disarmament as India does not need weapons of mass destruction to bully or threaten other nations.

India’s desire for economic autarky and self-sufficiency also has its roots in the almost zealous guarding of independence. The dominant streak among Indian policymakers and public has tended towards protectionism. While India as a developing country has always needed both foreign aid and foreign capital, it has never been comfortable with either. The fear of foreign capital and malevolence of foreigners goes back to colonial rule and the manner in which the East India Company transformed trade and investment into occupation.

The desire for self-sufficiency has also extended to the military arena, where India has sought to not only maintain large professional armed forces but also to equip them with weapons that can be manufactured at home. Nehru embraced the ideas of the German philosopher Kant and the internationalism associated with former US president Woodrow Wilson, but the Indian state veers towards a Hobbesian view of the world wherein India has to depend solely on itself.